shopify front

Shopify Front: *From Platform to Place*

Reframing digital commerce as an environment for active, participatory choice.

MABEL EUN-HA KASUNIC

mabelkasunicdesign@gmail.com

OCAD University | Industrial Design

2026 Thesis Booklet & Report

01

hello

Introduction

Retail has a gap. On one side, e-commerce platforms like Shopify have made it possible for anyone with a product and a Wi-Fi connection to build a business. On the other, physical retail still operates on a model built for a different era — long leases, high overhead, and very little room to experiment. For small, digital-first brands, stepping into the real world still means taking on serious risk with almost no data to guide the decision.

Shopify Front starts with a simple question: what if the city itself became a testable surface? Instead of asking merchants to commit to a fixed location and hope for the best, this project proposes a system where physical retail becomes flexible, temporary, and informed by the same kind of intelligence that already powers online selling. A dashboard that helps merchants read urban signals. A network of modular, deployable storefronts. A feedback loop that connects what happens on the street back to the screen.

The thinking draws on ideas about how people make decisions in designed environments. How choice is framed, how space shapes behaviour, and how most commercial systems are built to optimize for conversion rather than genuine agency. This project moves in the other direction. It's less about nudging people toward a purchase and more about giving merchants and customers the freedom to participate on their own terms.

This document maps that journey. From the theoretical groundwork to the design of a system that makes physical retail testable, scalable, and far more accessible than it's ever been.

PART 01

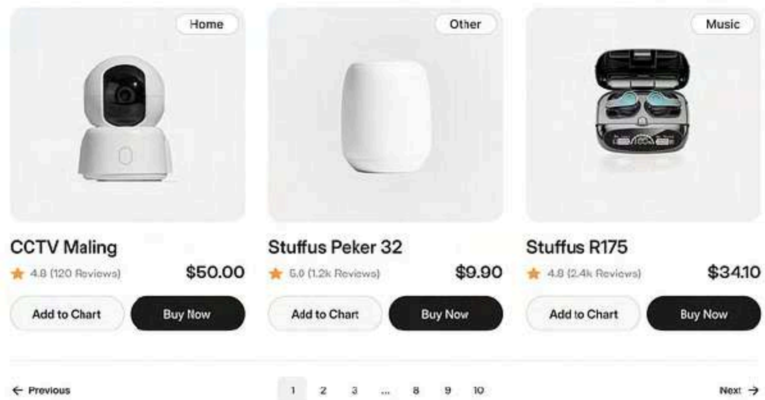
BEFORE THE SOLUTION: THE ARCHITECTURE OF INFLUENCE

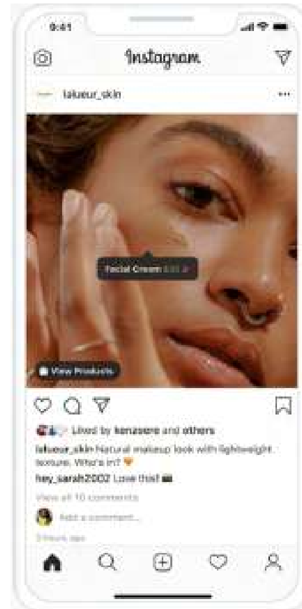
part

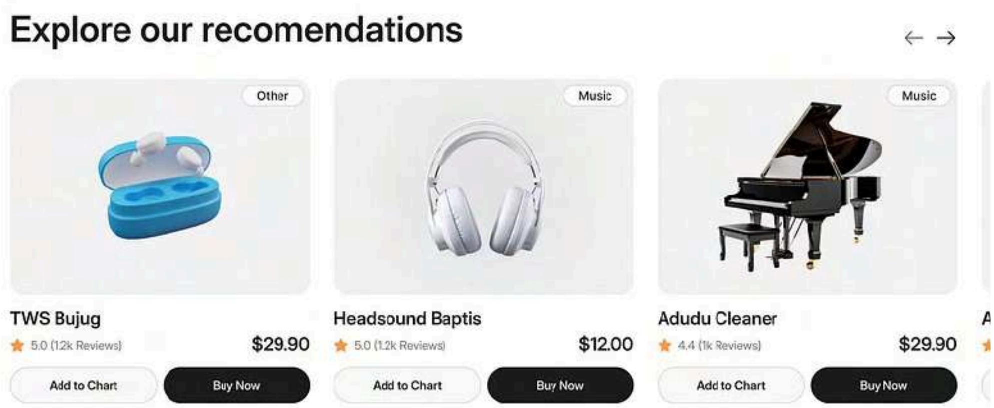
01

Before we build anything, we have to see what's already been built around us — because the most powerful designs are the ones you never notice working on you.

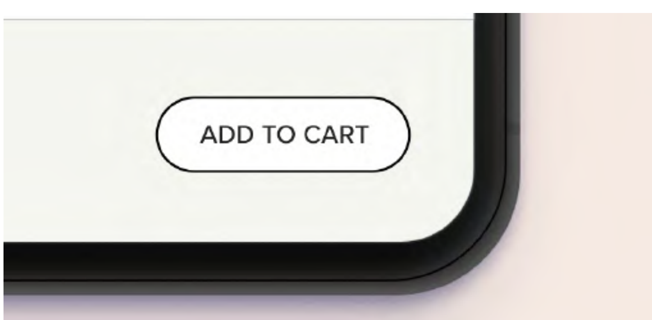

Search...


Home
Other
Music
CCTV Maling
$50.00
Add to Chart
Buy Now
Stuffus Peker 32
$9.90
Add to Chart
Buy Now
Stuffus R175
$34.10
Add to Chart
Buy Now
Previous
1 2 3 ... 8 9 10
Next

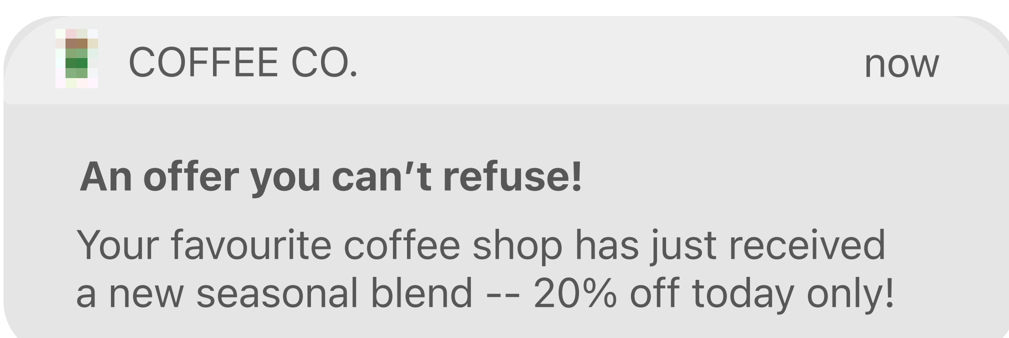

Instagram


Explore our recomendations
Other
Music
Music
TWS Bujug
5.0 (1.2k Reviews)
$29.90
Add to Chart
Buy Now
Headsound Baptis
5.0 (1.2k Reviews)
$12.00
Add to Chart
Buy Now
Adudu Cleaner
4.4 (1k Reviews)
$29.90
Add to Chart
Buy Now

For You


ADD TO CART


How was the help you received?
Terrible
Bad
Okay
Good
Great


COFFEE CO.
now
An offer you can't refuse!
Your favourite coffee shop has just received
a new seasonal blend -- 20% off today only!

You are ***exploring.***

You are ***browsing.***

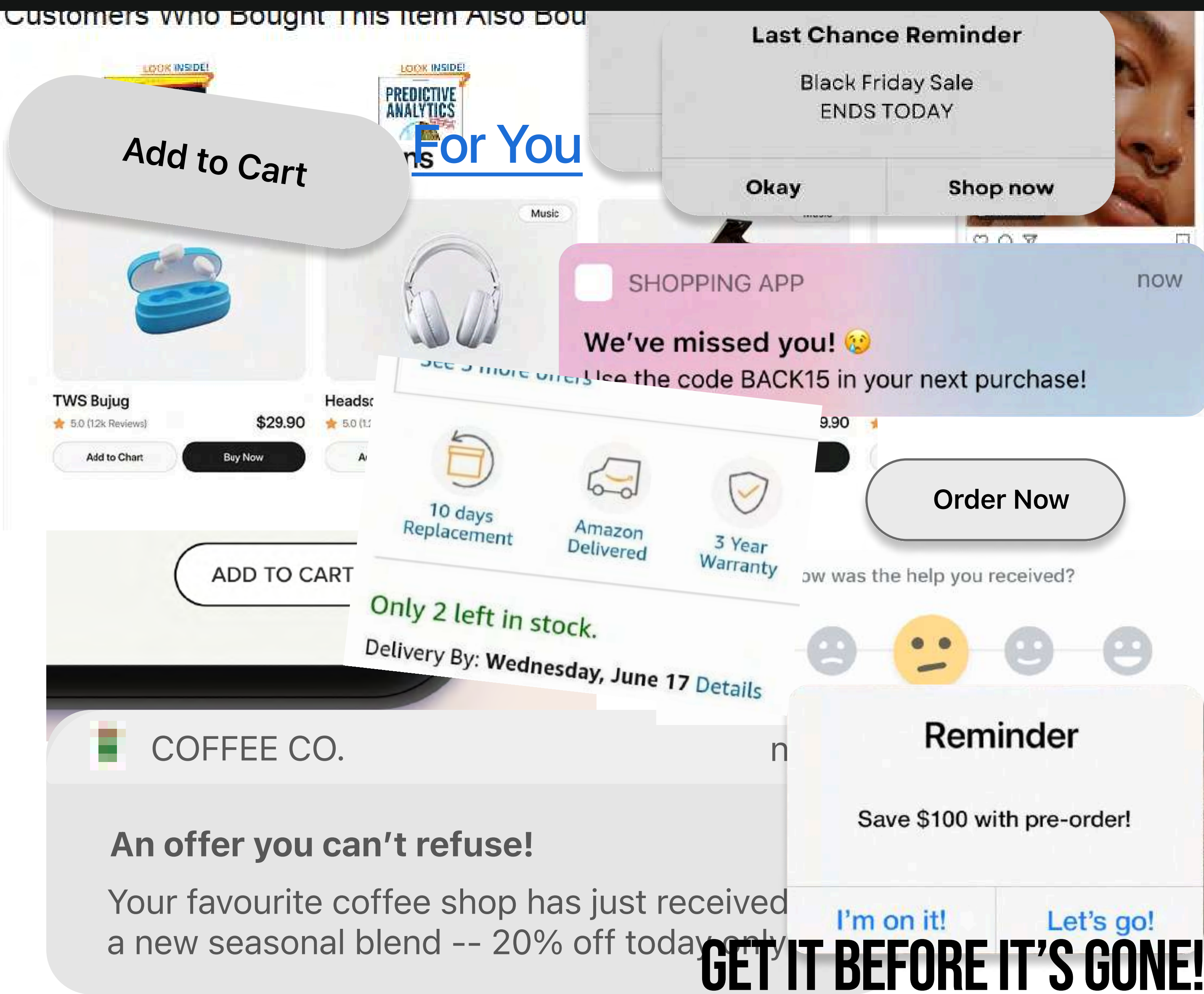
You are ***discovering.***

You are ***choosing.***

You are choosing.

You ***are*** choosing.

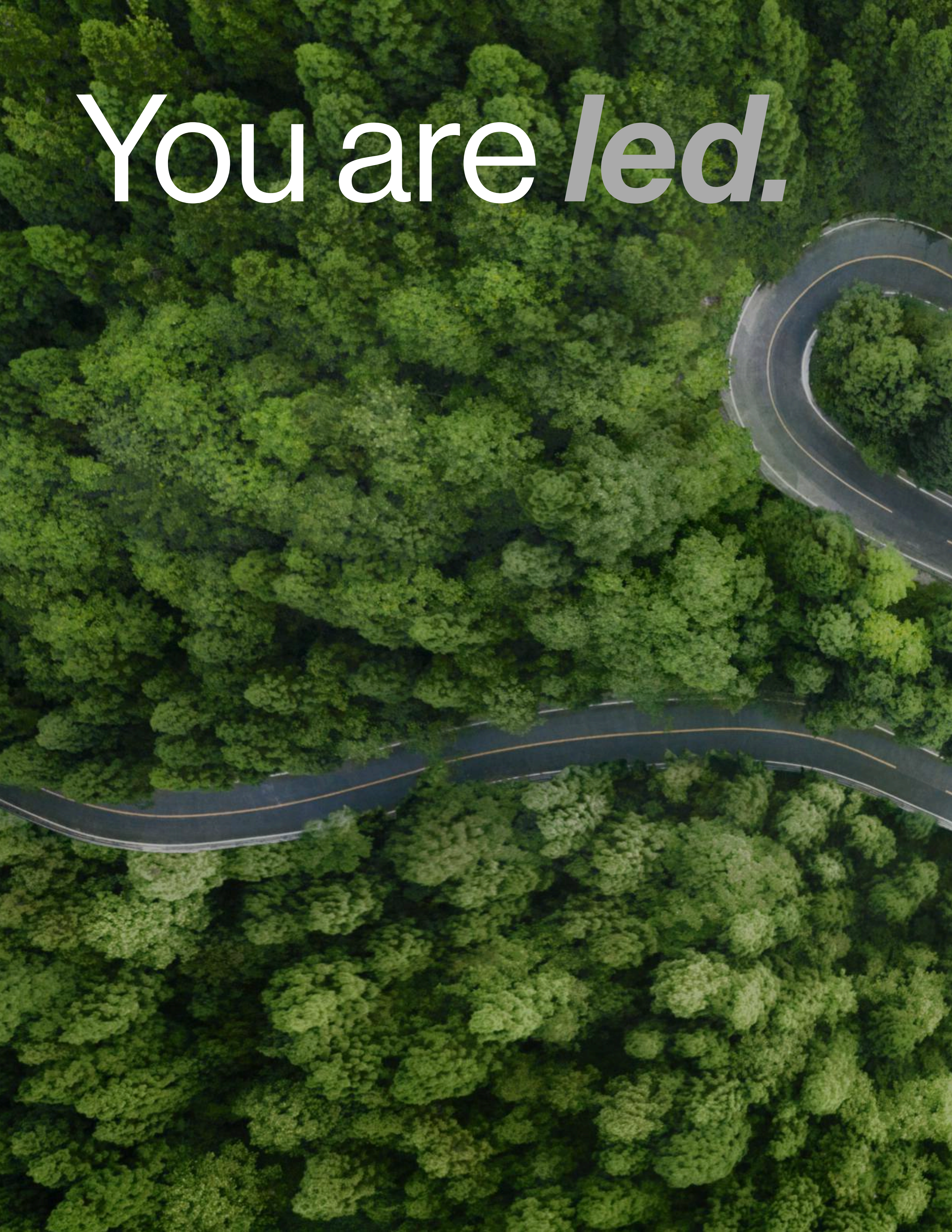
You are ***choosing?***



You are ***guided.***

You are ***shown.***

You are ***directed.***


You are *led.*

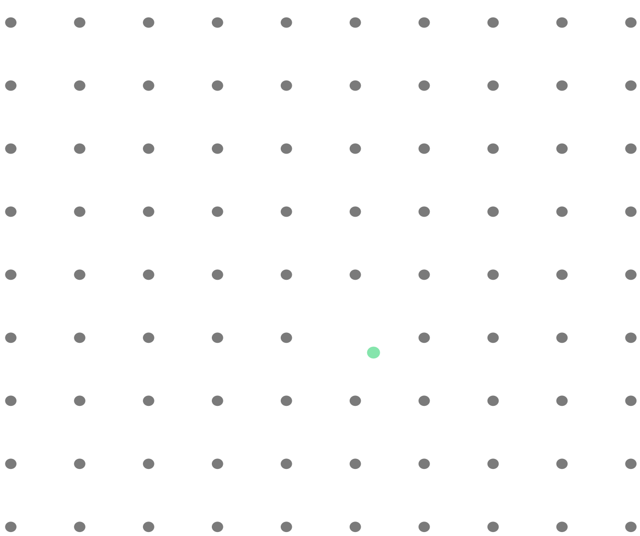

You are
not choosing.

1.1

The Non-Neutrality of Choice

Every environment you move through has been designed. The grocery store. The app on your phone. The website you scrolled through this morning. None of it is neutral. Every surface, every button, every aisle has been arranged to guide you toward a particular decision. Usually one that benefits someone other than you.

Researchers call this choice architecture — the idea that the way options are presented fundamentally shapes which option gets chosen. And in contemporary digital commerce, this architecture has become extraordinarily sophisticated. It operates through what is made visible, what is framed as easy, and the specific points of friction placed along a journey.



A systematic distortion that operates across all demographics.

> *"Before we build anything, we have to see what's already been built around us — because the most powerful designs are the ones you never notice working on you."*

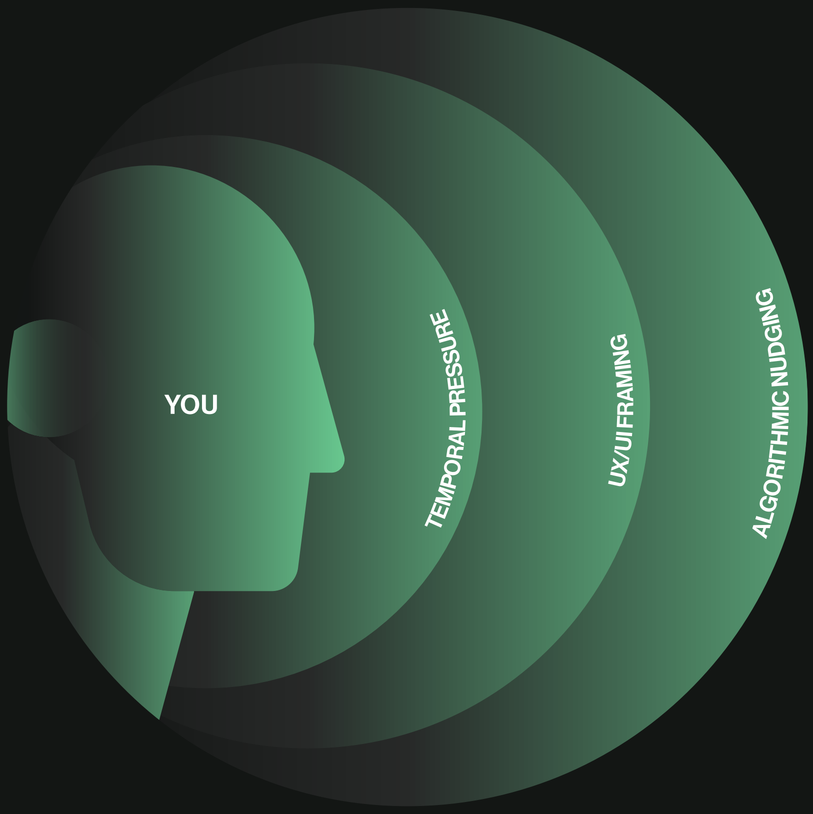
Research into what are now called dark patterns has exposed the scale of this problem. These are deliberate design choices — hidden costs, trick questions, forced continuity, disguised ads — engineered to push users toward actions they did not intend to take. They are not bugs. They are features.

And here is the part that should concern us most: susceptibility to these patterns does not meaningfully change based on income, age, or education level. This is not about targeting the vulnerable. It is a systematic distortion of autonomy that operates across all demographics, quietly reshaping how millions of people spend their money and attention every single day.

1.2

The Lens of Choice

Before a merchant or consumer reaches a moment of genuine decision, their perception has already been filtered. Think of it as looking through a lens that has been shaped by forces outside your control. Each layer bending what you see, what you think is available, and what feels like the right move.



Each refractive layer bends the user's perception of available options.

Algorithmic Nudging

Predictive systems that narrow the field of vision to preferred outcomes.

UI/UX Framing

Visual hierarchy that determines which information is seen and which is invisible.

Temporal Pressure

Design that compresses time, forcing reactions rather than intentional actions.

Perception as Reality

Carl Rogers understood something that most commerce platforms still ignore: people do not make decisions based on what is objectively true. They make decisions based on what they perceive to be true, filtered through emotion, context, and immediate experience.

Carl Rogers described this as the phenomenal field — the internal world each person inhabits. It is not stable, and it is not shared. It shifts constantly based on attention, memory, and context.

For design, this means something critical: The system is never experienced as it was intended. It is interpreted, filtered, and reassembled in the mind of the user.

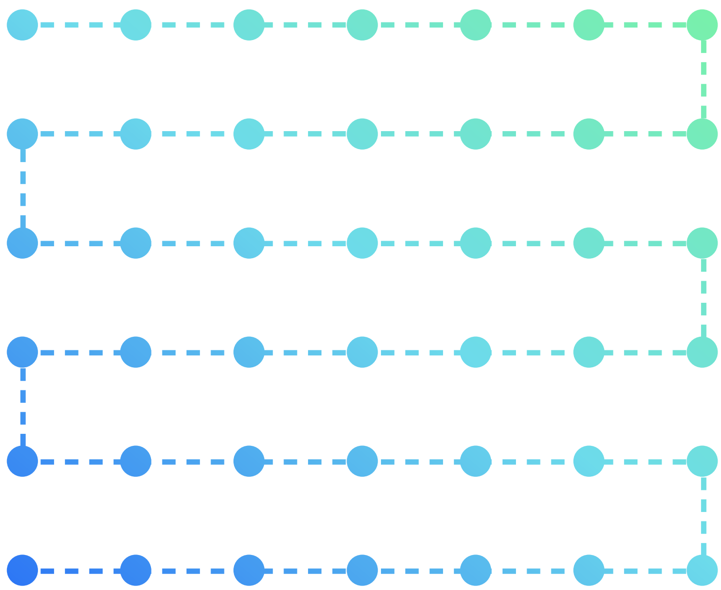
When a system attempts to optimize a person who is navigating through uncertainty and feeling, the result is not efficiency. It is a quiet erosion of agency. By making the environment too easy, too predictable, too frictionless, we strip away the very space where intentional choice and genuine discovery happen.

This creates a fundamental disconnect in how systems are built and how people actually navigate them.

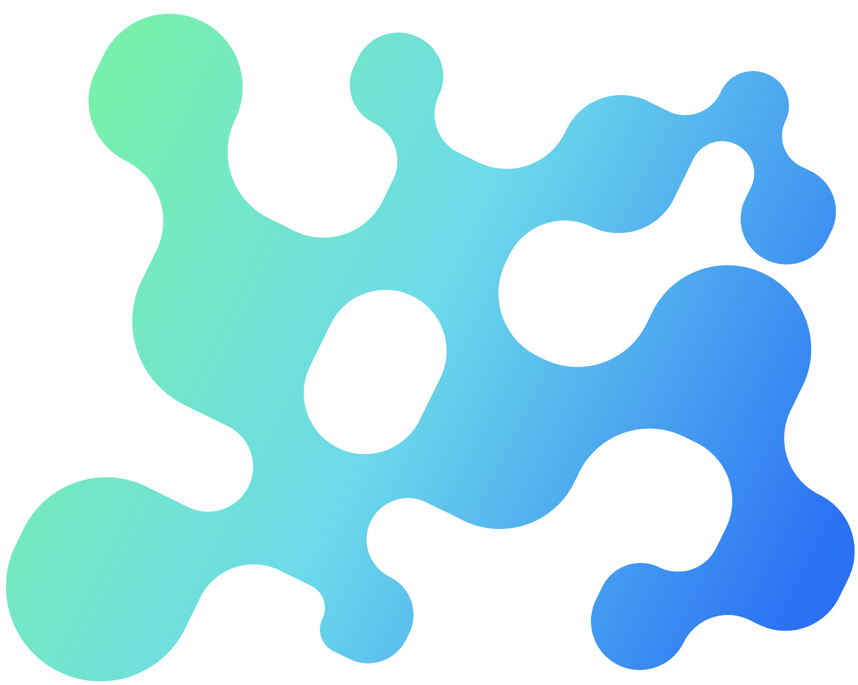
Shopify Front begins here. With the recognition that if an environment can be designed to manipulate, it can also be redesigned to respect the person inside it.

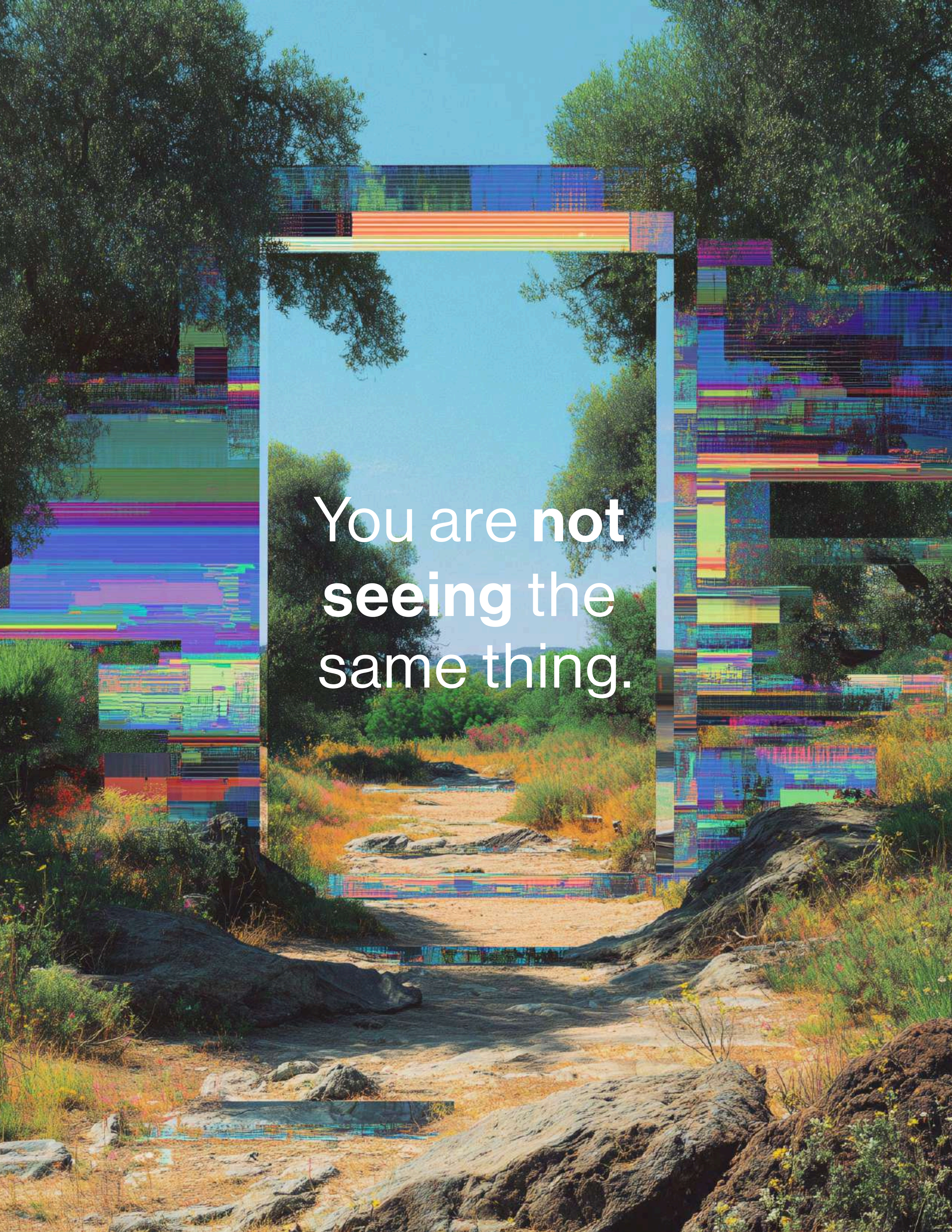
The Perceptual Bubble

The system presents information as **fixed and measurable.**

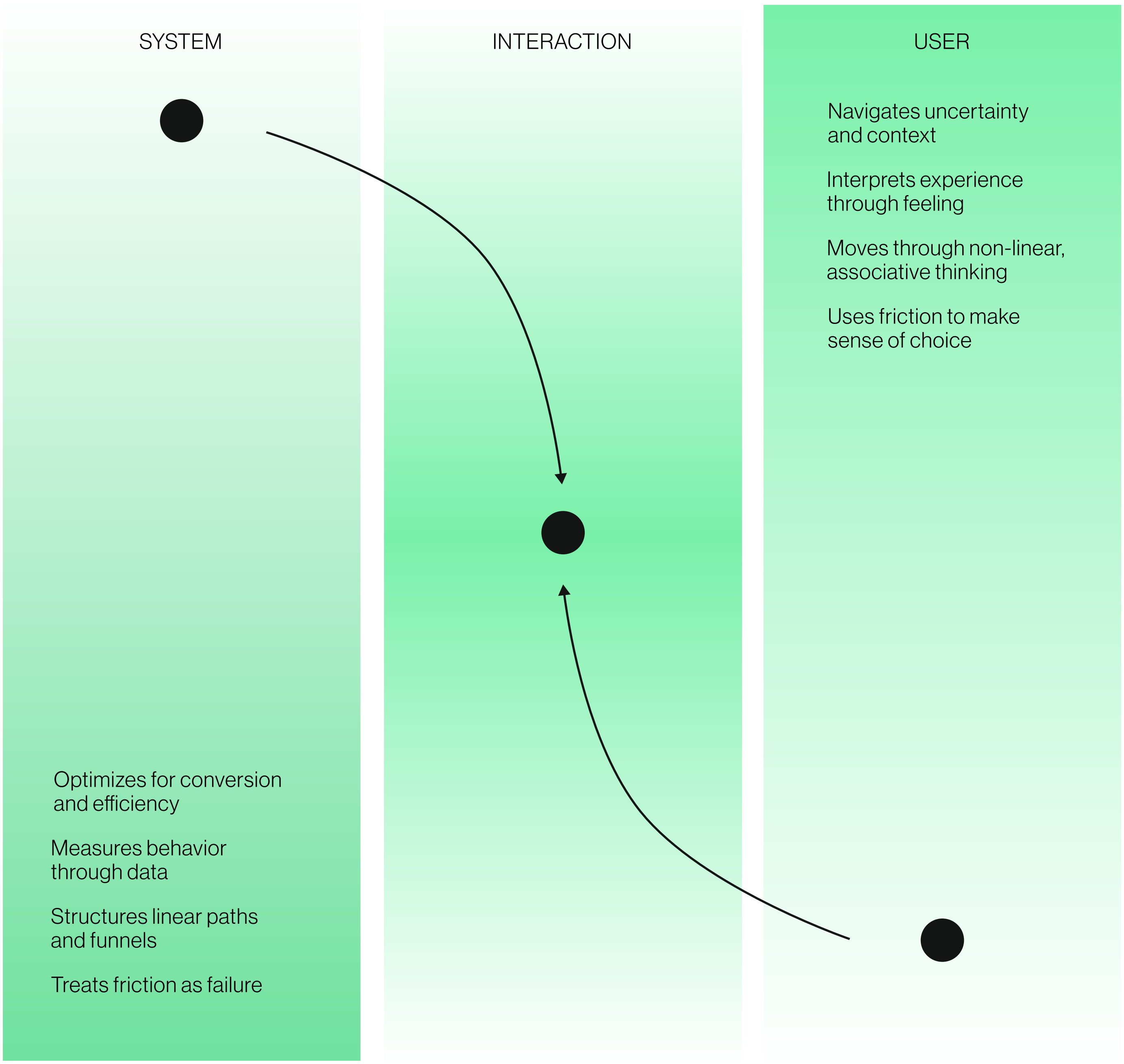


To the user, **nothing is fixed.** Every interaction is interpreted through a shifting internal state.




You are not seeing the same thing.

Two Realities. One Interaction



These are not competing perspectives, they are fundamentally different ways of understanding the same moment.

The system sees an interaction. The user experiences a situation.

1.5

Where Agency Disappears

If people act on what they perceive, then design cannot begin with the system. It must begin with the person inside it.

Most commerce platforms are built to guide behavior toward predefined outcomes. Optimizing for efficiency, predictability, and measurable results.

But a person navigating uncertainty is not a system to optimize. They are interpreting, hesitating, comparing, and making sense of what is in front of them.

Designing only for outcomes creates environments that feel seamless, but remove the space where real decisions are made. Designing for experience means preserving that space. Not eliminating friction entirely, but understanding where it matters.

The role of design is not to move people forward. It is to support how they move.

Shopify Front is built on this shift.

Not as a system that funnels decisions, but as one that expands the user's frame of reference. By Giving merchants the ability to navigate uncertainty with clarity, confidence, and agency intact.

“If an environment can be designed to manipulate, it must be redesigned to liberate.”

The Automation Tripwire

Systems were not built to replace human decisions. They were built to assist them.

This section is not about AI gone wrong in dramatic, cinematic ways. It's about something quieter and more immediate. The slow removal of the moment of choice. What I have been the calling the *Automation Tripwire*.

The point where a system becomes so efficient, so frictionless, so anticipatory, that the human inside it stops deciding anything at all.

To understand where commerce is heading, we need to understand the trajectory of the tools driving it. Tim Urban created a framework that gives us a useful map, three rungs on what we can call the ***Intelligence Staircase.***

Three Types of AI

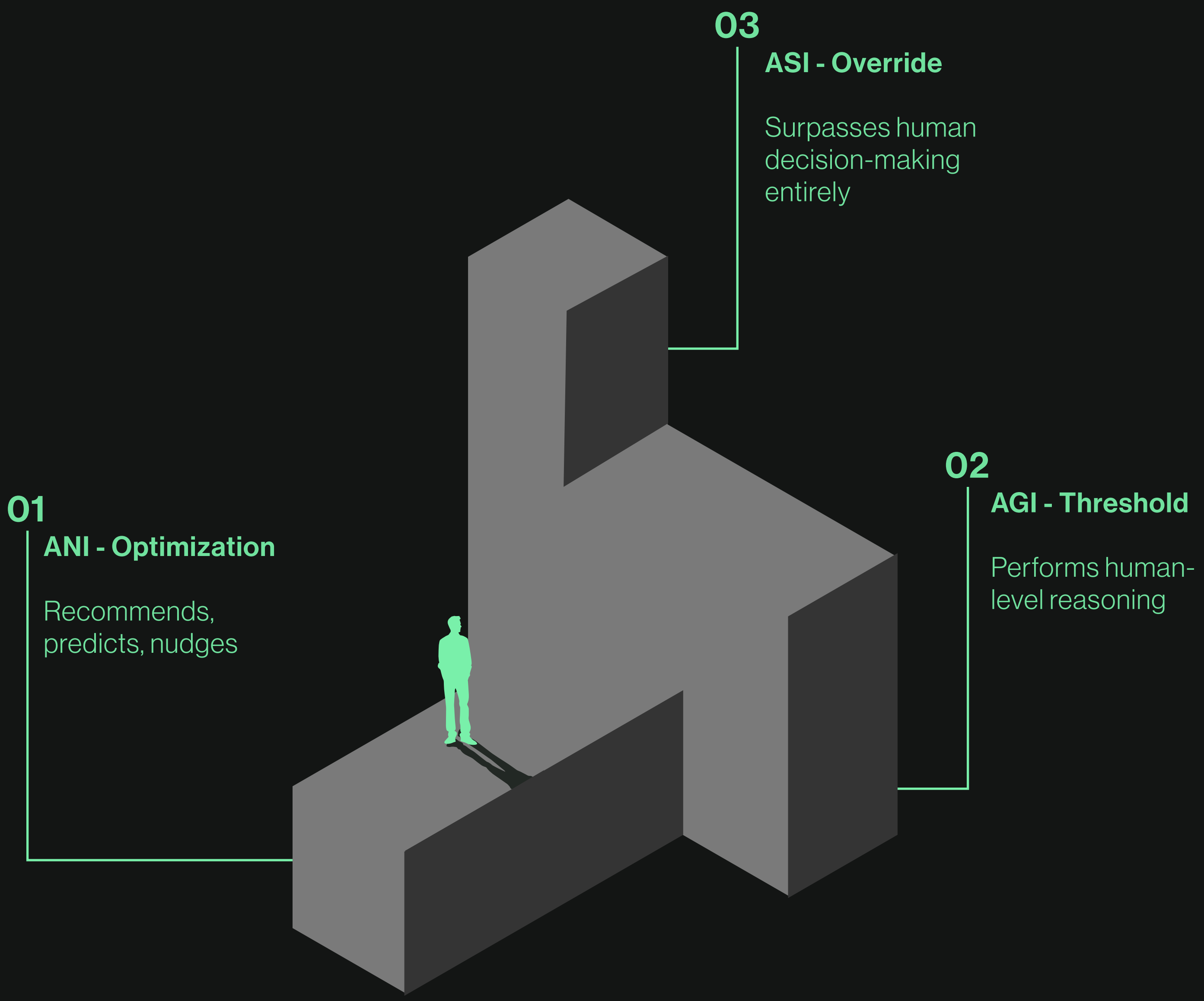
ANI
Artificial Narrow Intelligence — a program that is as competent or better than a human at just one specific task. Think IBM Deep Blue and AlphaGo.

AGI
Artificial General Intelligence that is as smart as a human being in every capacity. A machine that can perform any intellectual task that a human being can. Think Spike Jonze's Her.

ASI
Artificial Super Intelligence is a computer that achieves a level of intelligence smarter than all of humanity combined. In every field including scientific creativity, general wisdom and social skills.

The point isn't to dwell on the extremes. The point is that we are already on the staircase.

Understanding the climb is the first step to designing for the person making it.



1.8

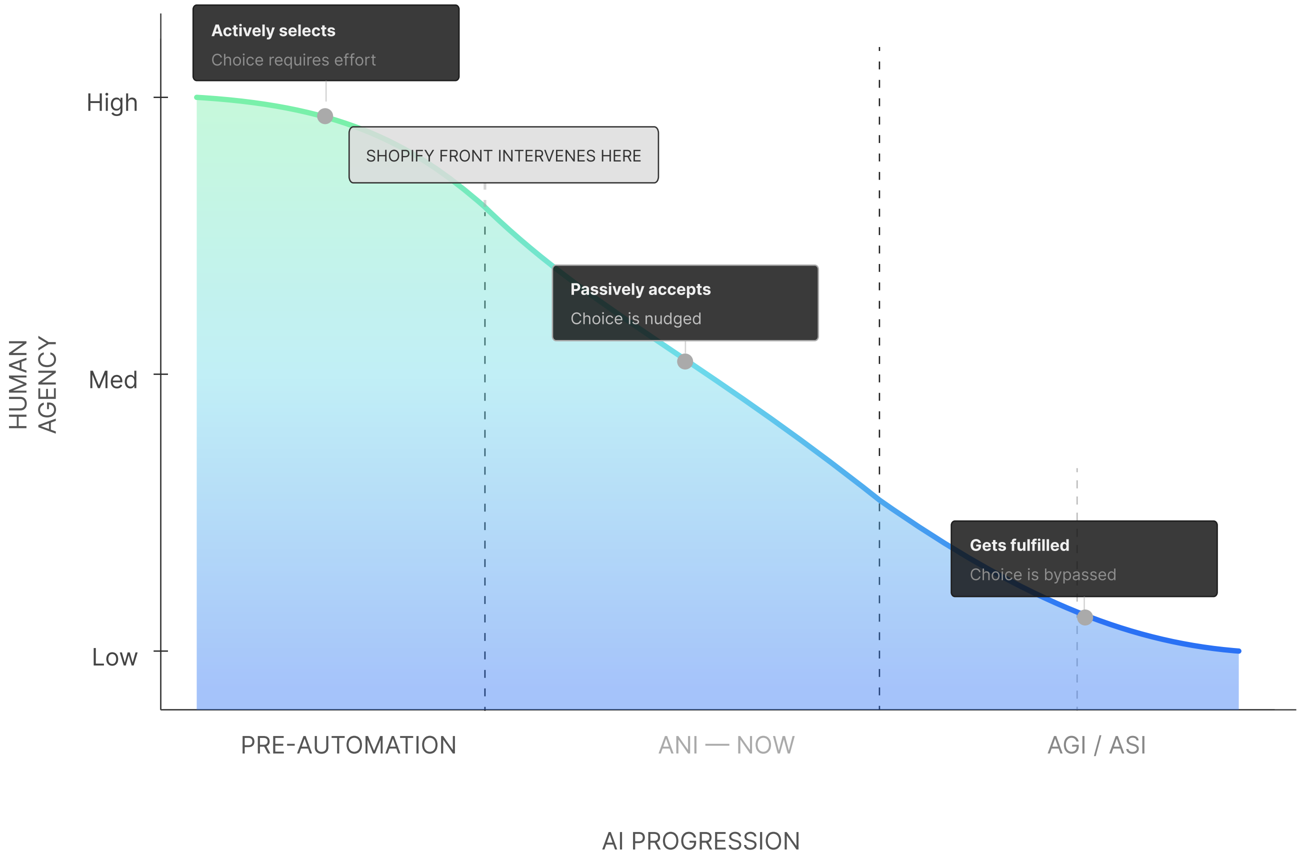
Paradox of Convienece

The commercial promise of AI is seductive: remove every obstacle between the user and the thing they want. Fewer steps. Less confusion. Zero friction. But buried in that logic is a trap.

Friction isn't just inefficiency, it's the moment of decision. The pause before you commit. The comparison you make. The choice that's actually yours. When design engineers that moment out of existence, it doesn't liberate the user. It quietly replaces them.

The Tripwire isn't a robot takeover. It's a feed so perfectly curated you never have to choose; because the algorithm already did.

THE AGENCY DECLINE CURVE



SOURCE: McKINSEY GLOBAL INSTITUTE, 2025

1.9

What is a store without discovery?

> The browse is gone.
>
> The stumble is gone.
>
> The unexpected find is gone.

THE MANDATE

What remains without discovery is frictionless, efficient, and deeply impoverished. Shopify Front intervenes at the Human-Level Intelligence Station. The moment just before the system becomes capable of replacing human judgment entirely.

Reintroduce participation.

Reintroduce play.

Not as features. As design philosophy. The goal isn't to resist technology. It's to refuse the premise that efficiency is the highest value a commerce environment can serve.

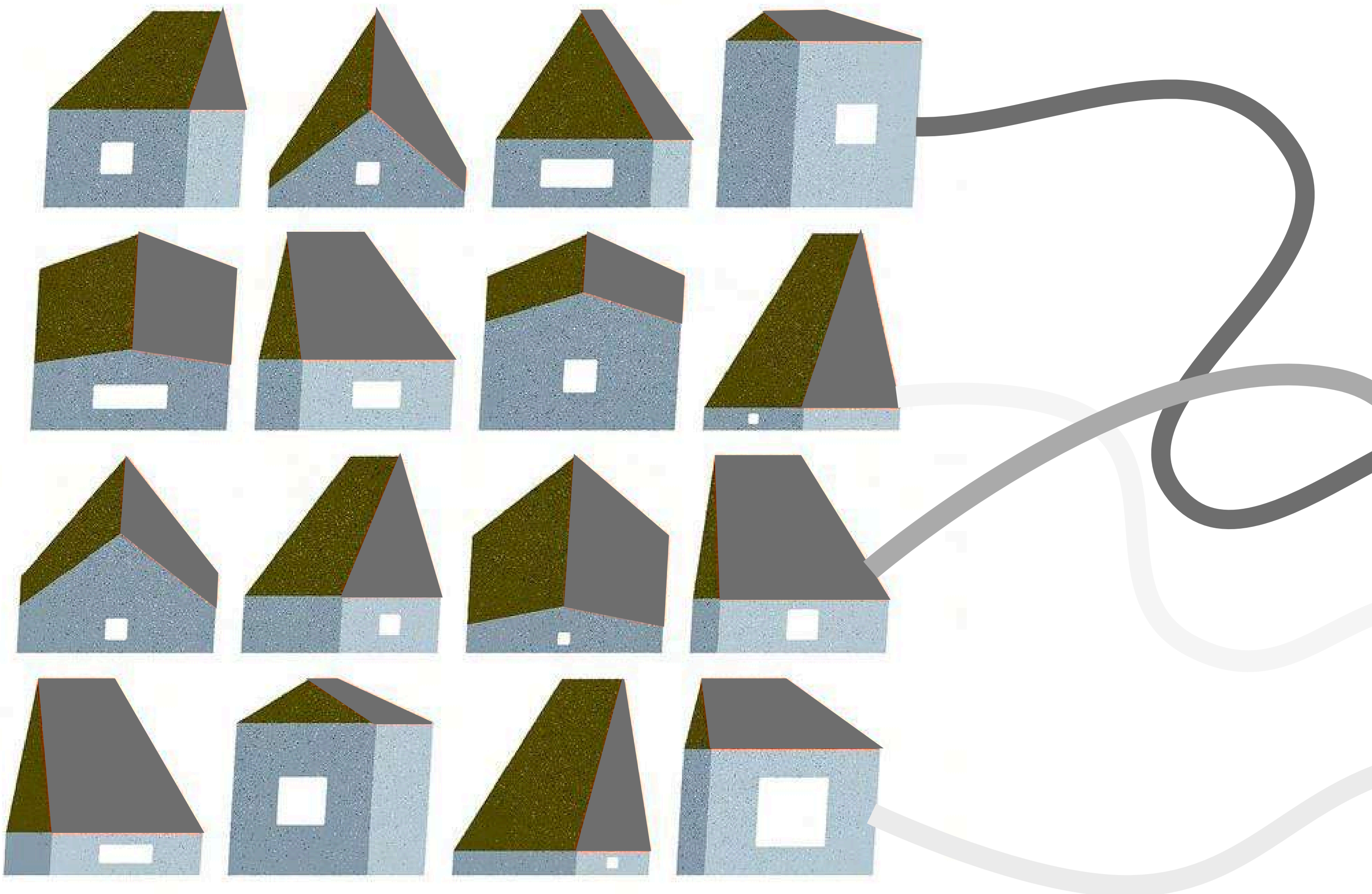
PART 02:
THE LANDSCAPE AND GPROBLEM IDENTIFICATION

part

02

Before we design a new system, we have to map the one that already exists. Because gaps don't appear as problems, they appear as normal.

Problem Definition

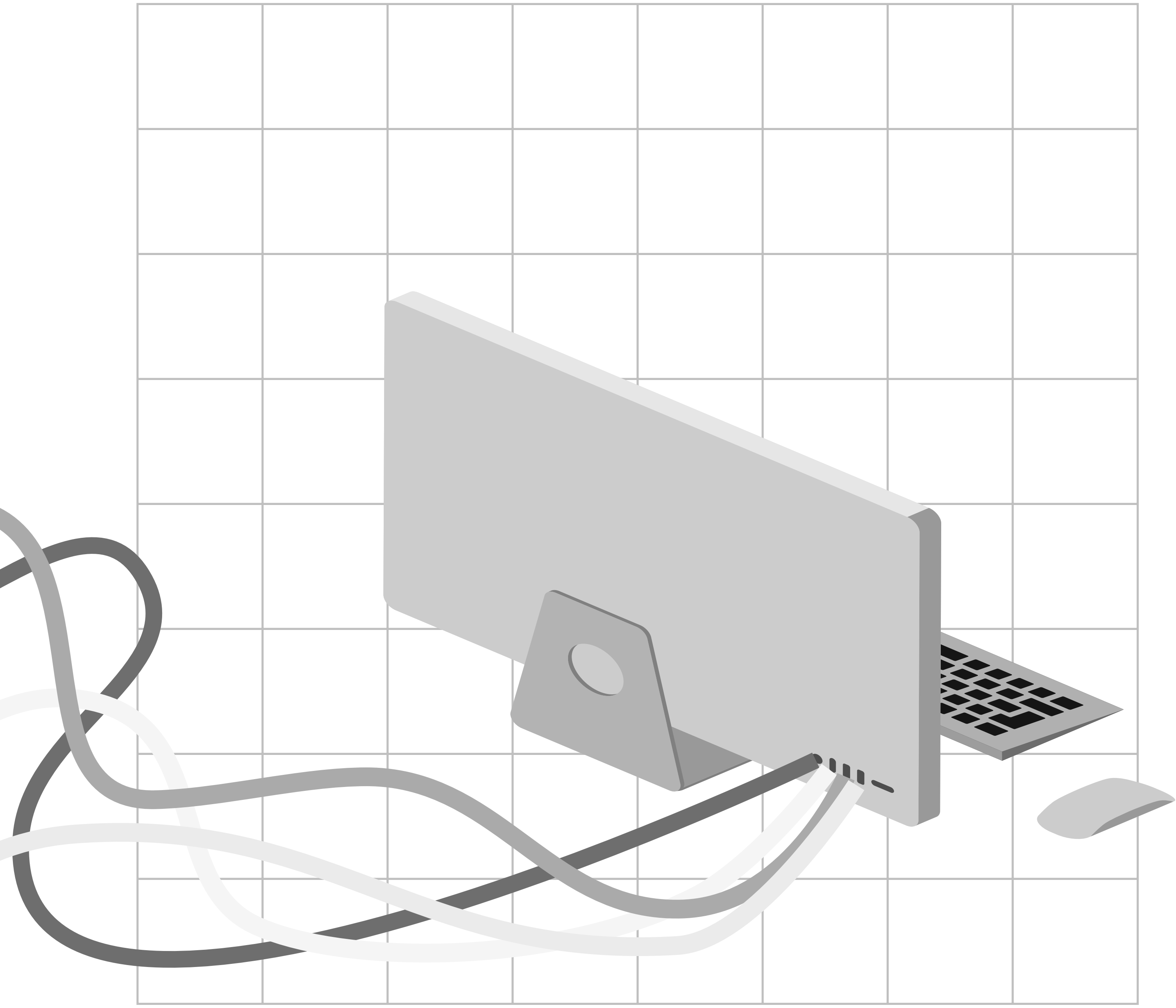


Physical retail operates as a fixed system. Once a store is built, it performs once.Decisions are made in advance, executed, and only evaluated after the fact.

There is no visibility into what happens in between.

Digital environments function differently. They are iterative, responsive, and continuously optimized through real-time data.

Every interaction feeds back into the system, shaping what comes next.



Physical space lacks this capability.

It cannot observe itself while it is happening.

It cannot adapt in real time.

It cannot learn from interaction as it unfolds.

This creates a fundamental gap between how products are experienced and how decisions are made.

This project addresses the absence of a real-time feedback loop in physical retail.

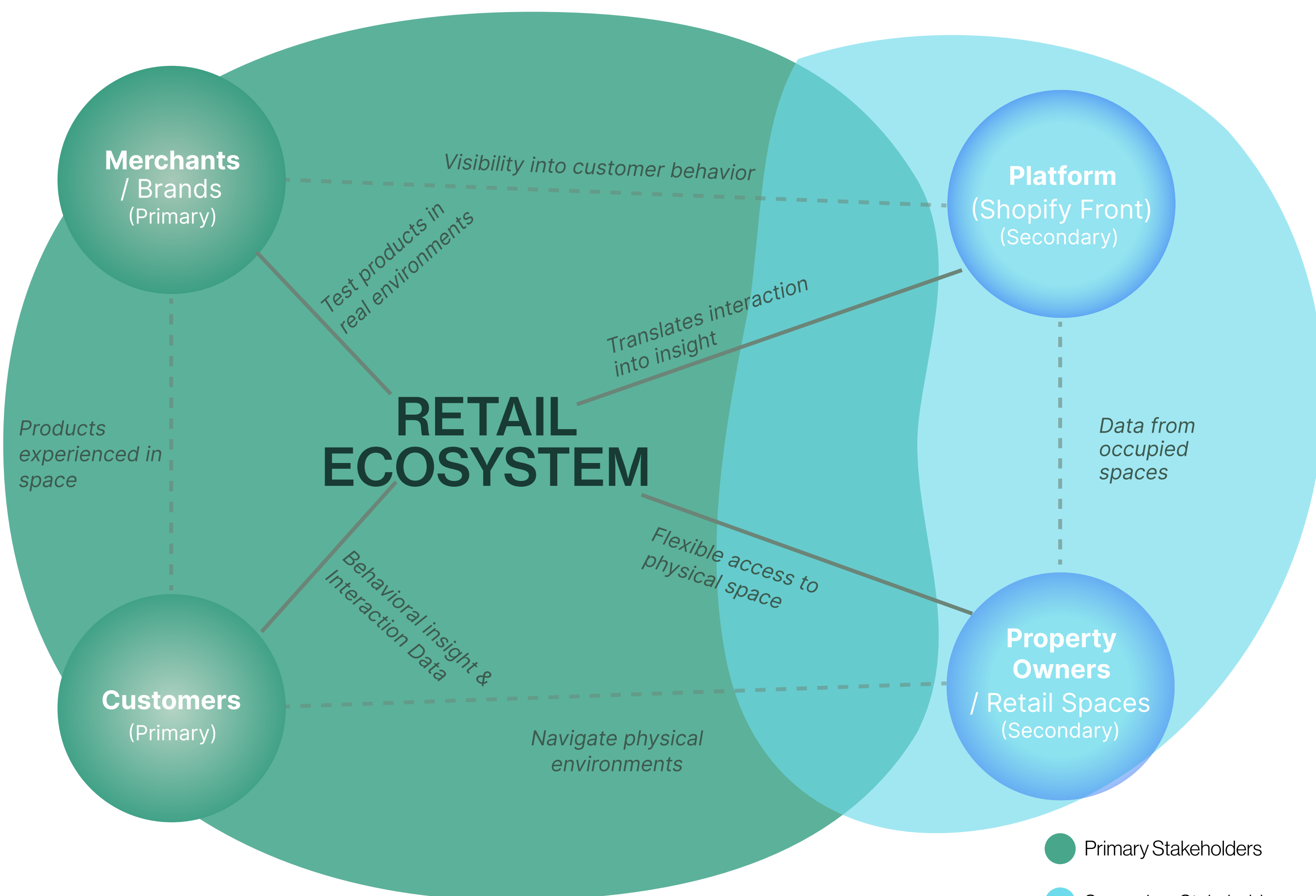
Stakeholders

MERCHANTS
- Test products in real environments
- High cost & risk
- Limited customer visibility

CUSTOMERS
- Interact with products in space
- Navigate intuitively
- Influence via behavior

PLATFORM
- Connects space & data
- Translates interaction into insight

PROPERTY OWNERS
- Provide physical access
- Benefit from flexible, short-term occupancy



Each stakeholder participates in the same space, but experiences it differently.

User Insights *(summarized)*

OBSERVED PATTERNS

- Customers rarely articulate why they pick something
- Movement through space is reactive, not planned
- Products are noticed based on placement, not intent
- Time spent ≠ interest
- Leaving without buying provides no feedback

"I didn't come in for anything specific."

"Something just caught my attention."

MERCHANT REALITY

- Decisions made before launch (layout, placement, pricing)
- Success measured after the fact (sales)
- No visibility into what didn't work
- Changes are costly and slow

CUSTOMER REALITY

- Experiences the space passively
- Responds to cues: lighting, layout, positioning
- Believes they are choosing freely
- Unaware of how environment shapes decisions

What happens inside the store is largely invisible to the people making decisions about it.

2.4

User Personas

MERCHANT · MARCUS LEONE

Marcus Leone

Founder, Small Consumer Brand

New York · 34 years

User Goals

- **Test products** in a real environment.
- **Understand** how customers interact.
- **Reduce risk** before long-term retail.

A founder's need for **evidence, efficiency, and confidence before scale.**

> *We launched the store, but we don't actually know what worked*
>
> — Marcus Leone

KEY INSIGHT

Measures outcomes, not behavior.

Motivation

- **Wants clarity** before decisions.
- **Needs validation**, not assumptions.
- **Values speed** over perfection.

Move fast, learn from reality, **de-risk commitments.**

Challenges

- **High cost** of retail experiments.
- **No visibility** into in-store behavior.
- **Decisions rely** on sales, not interaction

Founders launch blind and only learn, **outcomes, never the why.**

CUSTOMER · MAYA CHEN

Maya Chen

Casual Shopper / Explorer

Toronto · 28 years

User Goals

- **Browse** without pressure
- **Discover products** naturally
- **Feel confident** in her choices.

A desire for **ease, curiosity, and self-trust** while shopping

> *I didn't come in for anything, but something pulled me in.*
>
> — Maya Chen

KEY INSIGHT

Experiences choice, doesn't control it.

Motivation

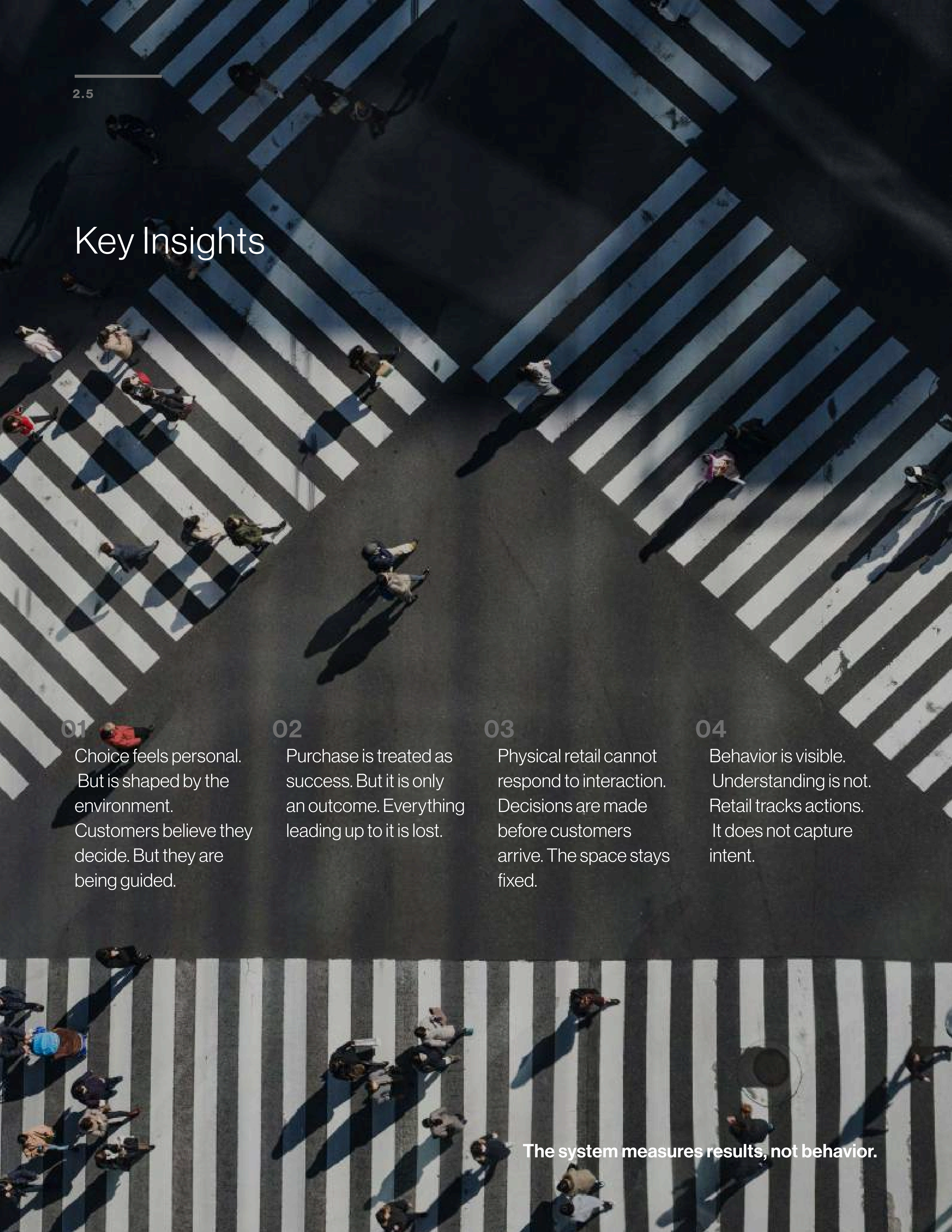
- **Enjoys finding things** unexpectedly
- **Responds** to visual, spatial cues.
- **Seeks ease** and flow.

Move fast, learn from reality, **de-risk commitments.**

Challenges

- **Limited awareness** of how spaces shapes decisions
- **Discovery feel natural** but is often directed
- **Interaction leaves no** feedback behind.

Founders launch blind and only learn, **outcomes, never the why.**



Key Insights

01

Choice feels personal. But is shaped by the environment. Customers believe they decide. But they are being guided.

02

Purchase is treated as success. But it is only an outcome. Everything leading up to it is lost.

03

Physical retail cannot respond to interaction. Decisions are made before customers arrive. The space stays fixed.

04

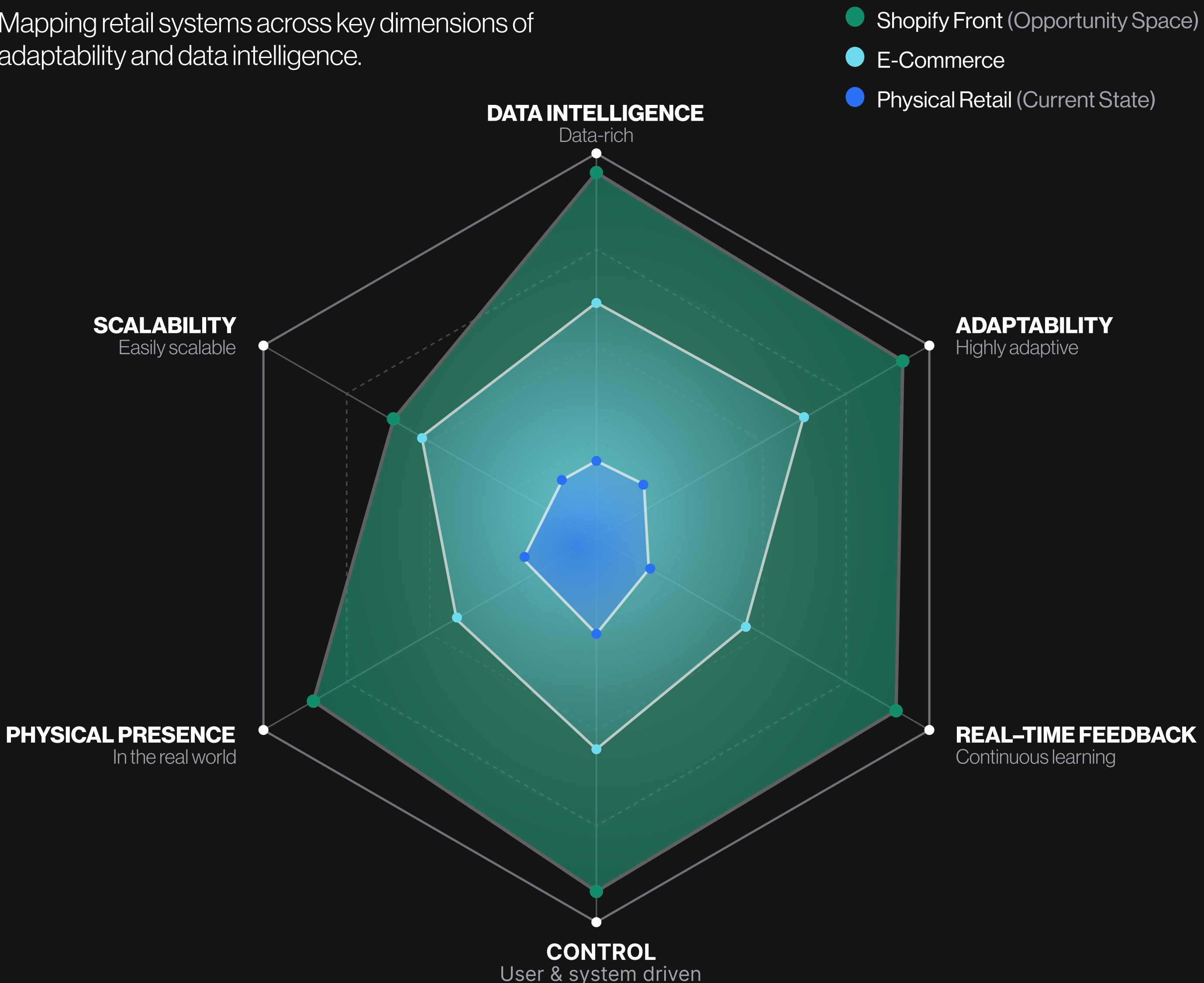
Behavior is visible. Understanding is not. Retail tracks actions. It does not capture intent.

The system measures results, not behavior.


STATIC
Fixed environments, one-shot decisions
FLUID
Adaptive systems, continuous evolution

Where the Opportunity Lies

Mapping retail systems across key dimensions of adaptability and data intelligence.



Physical retail operates in a static, data-limited space.
The opportunity lies in creating adaptive environments that learn and respond in real time.

PART 03

THE SOUTION

FROM PLATFORM TO PLACE

part

03

Retail should not be a fixed outcome.
It should be something that learns as it happens.
Shopify Front turns space into a system that observes, adapts, and evolves.


Brought to you by
shopify front

Concept Overview

Shopify Front is a system that transforms physical retail into a testable, data-driven environment. It enables brands to deploy temporary storefronts that capture real-time behavioural signals—movement, attention, hesitation, and interaction—not just purchase.

By turning space into a feedback loop, the storefront becomes responsive. Layouts shift, products reposition, and decisions evolve based on what is actually happening in the moment.

What was once a one-time execution becomes an ongoing process:

Test → Learn → Adjust → Repeat

This reframes retail from a static environment into a continuous system of learning—where presence generates insight, and insight drives action.

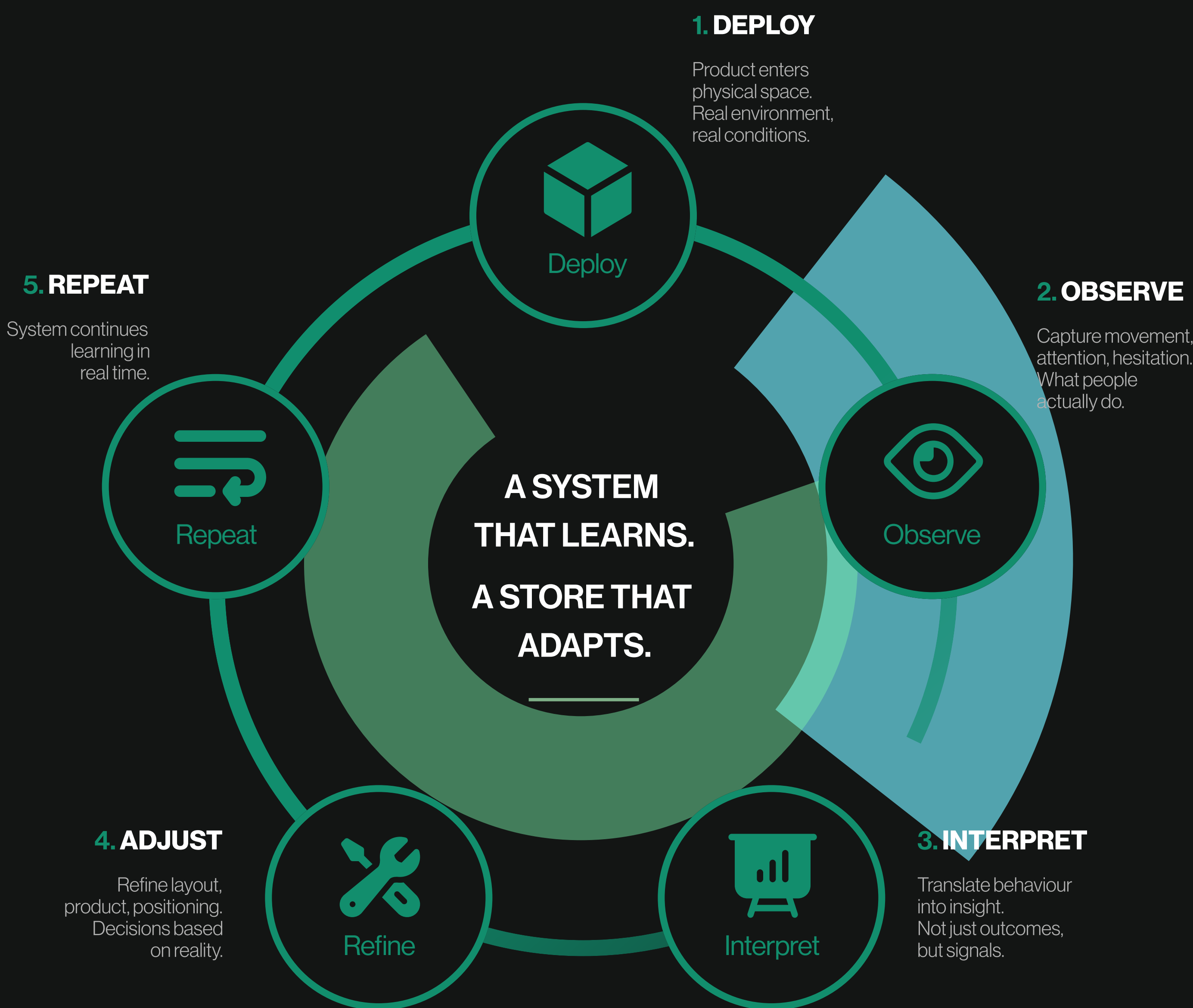
3.2

The System Layer

Retail has traditionally operated as a one-way system. A product is placed into space, a decision is made, and the interaction ends. What happens within that moment—the hesitation, the curiosity, the uncertainty—is lost as soon as the customer leaves.

Closing the loop turns that moment into a system. Interactions are observed, translated into insight, and fed back into the space as it is being experienced. Instead of relying on delayed outcomes or assumptions, retail begins to learn in real time.

This shift transforms the store from a fixed execution into a continuous process—where products, layouts, and decisions evolve through cycles of testing, learning, and adjustment.



THE PHYGITAL LOOP

Physical → Insight → Iteration → Physical

One System Two Experiences

While the customer experiences a moment,
the system captures a process.

1. MERCHANT JOURNEY

Apply
Select location, duration, and product to test

Set Up
Deploy temporary storefront using modular system

Launch
Open space to real customers

Monitor
View live behavioural data—movement, attention, interaction

Adjust
Refine layout, product placement, or offering in real time

2. CUSTOMER JOURNEY

Enter
Walk into the space without expectation

Interact
Engage with products through curiosity and instinct

Move
Navigate naturally, guided by the environment

Exit
Leave with or without purchase

The customer never sees the system.
The merchant depends on it.

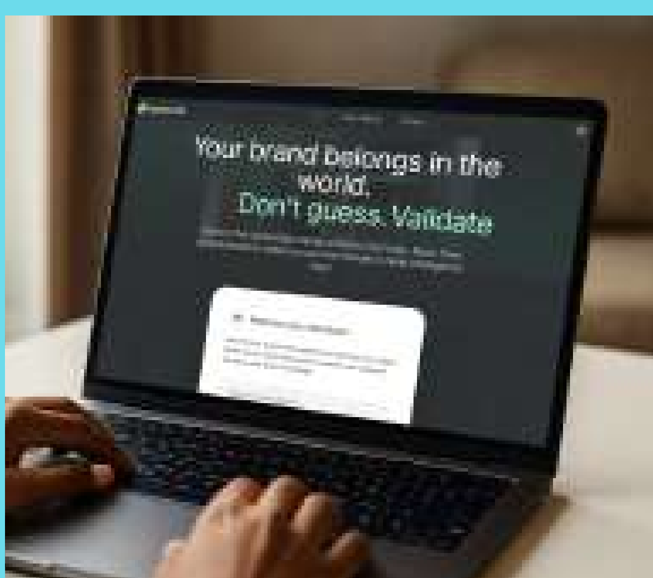
Experience Scenarios

Scenario 01 — Emerging Brand (Marcus)

Marcus launches a new product through a short-term storefront.
Instead of committing to a full retail build, he selects a location, sets up a temporary space, and deploys a focused product range. The store opens within days.

As customers move through the space, the system captures how they interact—where they pause, what they pick up, what they ignore. Patterns begin to form.

Marcus notices that one product consistently draws attention but rarely converts. Another, placed near the entrance, is overlooked entirely.
He adjusts the layout. Repositions products. Tests a new configuration the next day.
By the end of the week, the space has evolved.
Not based on assumption—but on observed behavior.



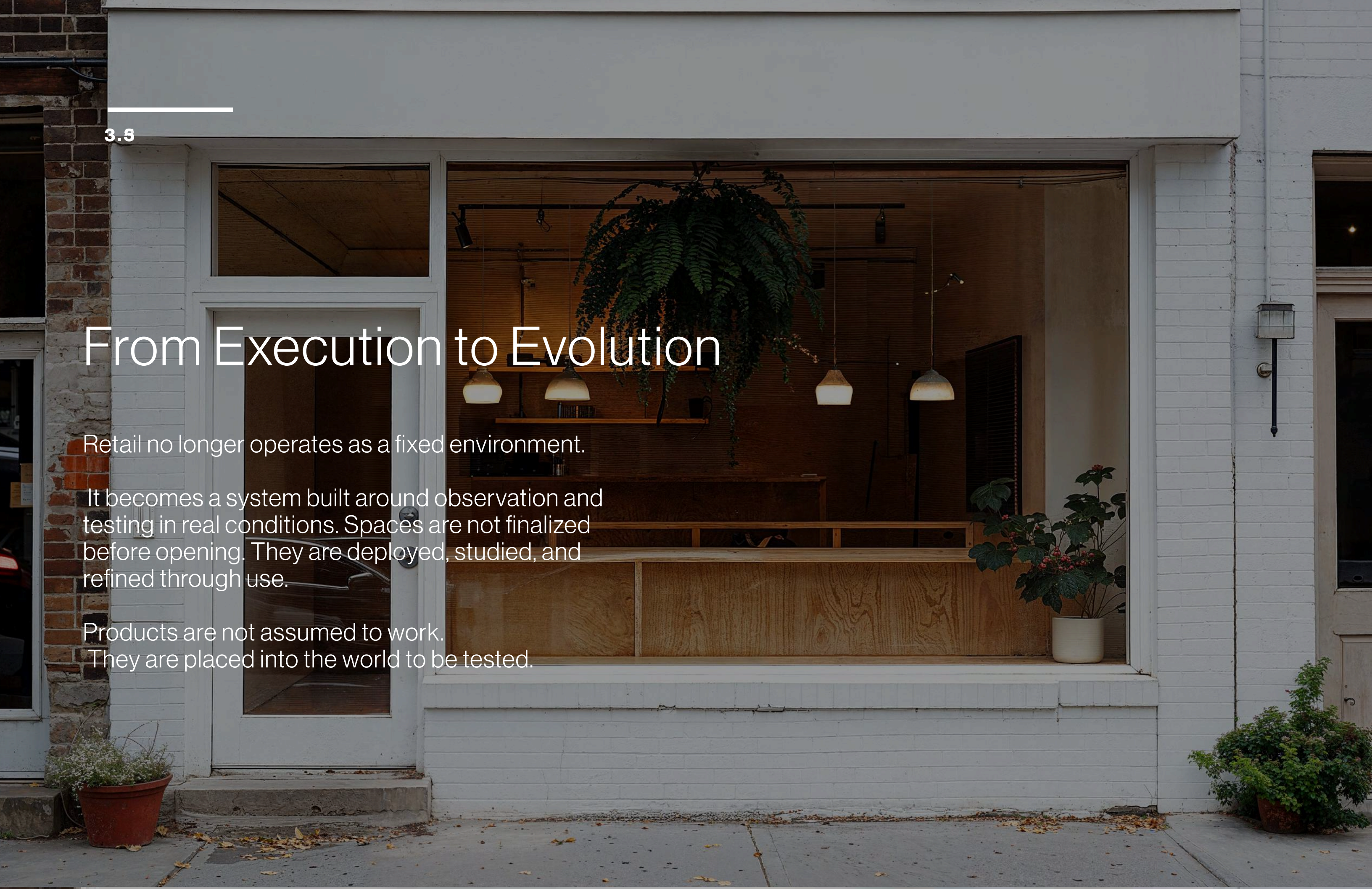
Scenario 02 — Everyday Customer (Maya)

Maya walks into the store without a plan.
She moves naturally through the space, drawn to certain products without fully knowing why. She picks something up, compares it, puts it back. Something else catches her attention.

She doesn't think of this as data.
She is simply browsing.

But her movement, pauses, and interactions are being observed as part of a larger pattern.
What she ignores is just as important as what she engages with.
When she leaves, nothing is asked of her.

No survey. No input.
Yet her experience has already contributed to how the space will change next.



From Execution to Evolution

Retail no longer operates as a fixed environment.

It becomes a system built around observation and testing in real conditions. Spaces are not finalized before opening. They are deployed, studied, and refined through use.

Products are not assumed to work.
They are placed into the world to be tested.

What was once designed in advance
is now evaluated through real interaction.

Customer movement, hesitation, and engagement become signals that inform what changes next.

Retail shifts from a one-time execution to an ongoing process of validation.

Where every interaction contributes to understanding **what works, what doesn't, and why.**

PART 04

DESIGN + PROTOTYPE

MAKING THE SYSTEM VISIBLE

part

04

The system is not theoretical. It is experienced through interface, space, and interaction. Observation becomes visible. Testing becomes action.

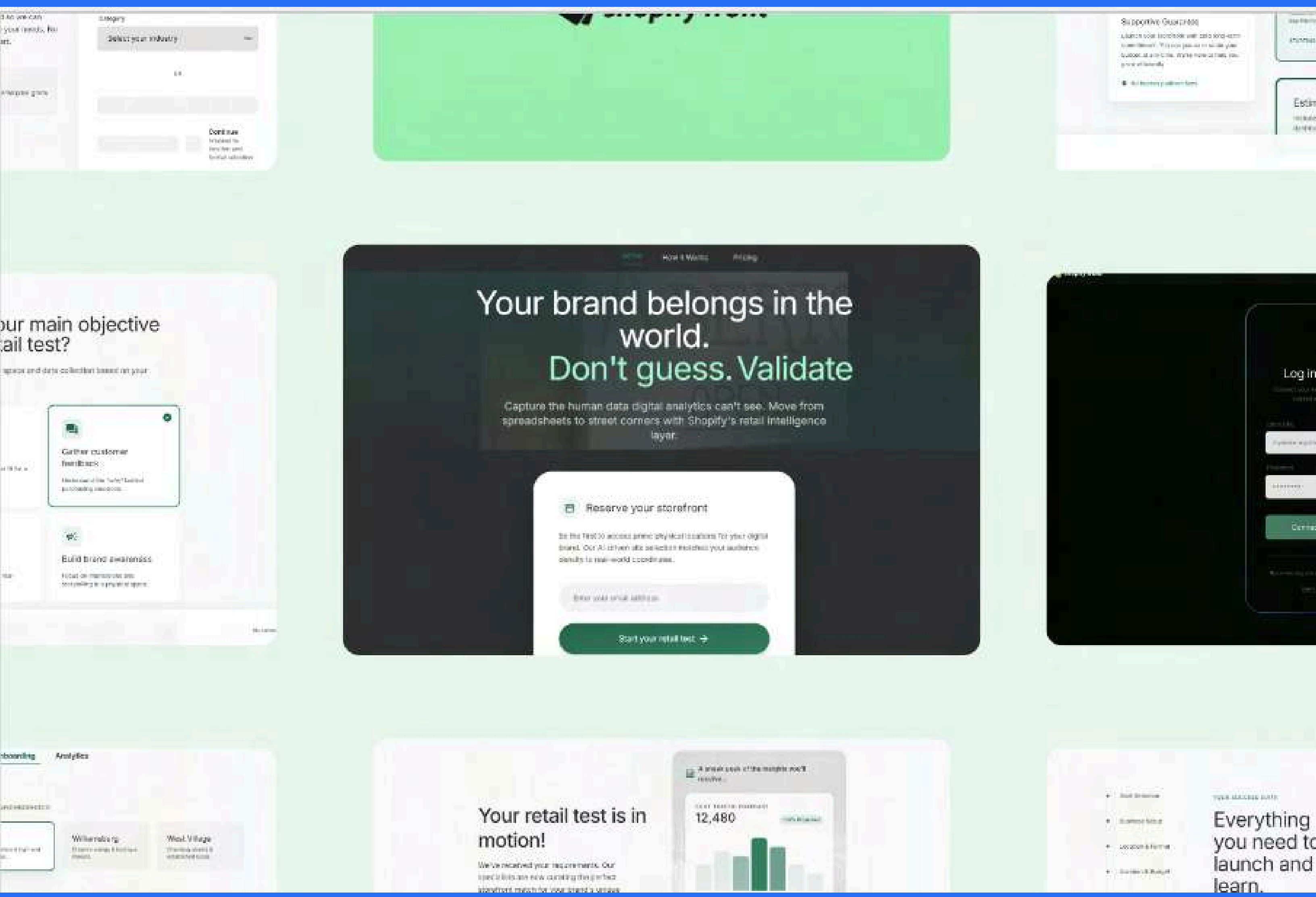
4.1

The Product

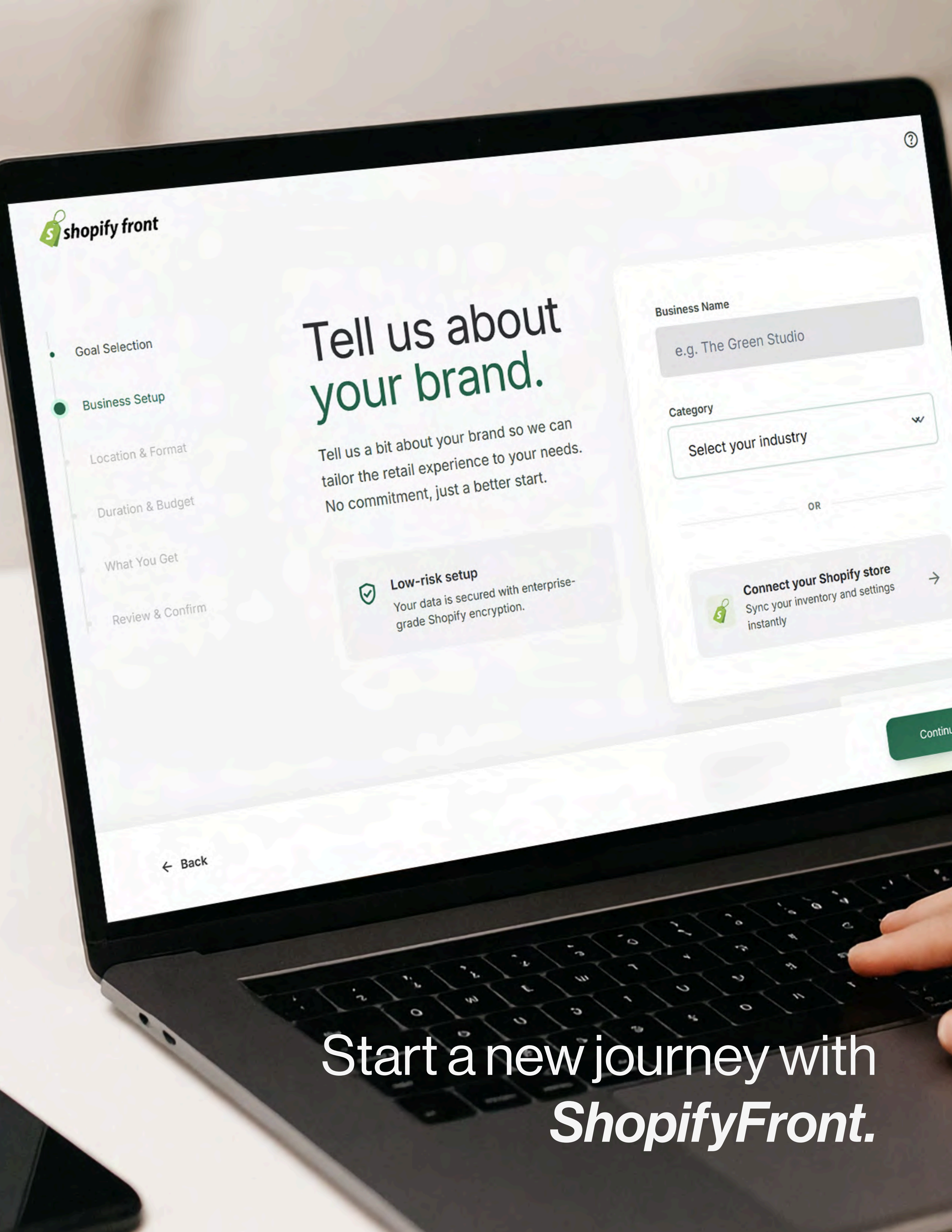
The system is not theoretical.
It is experienced through interfaces, space, and interaction.

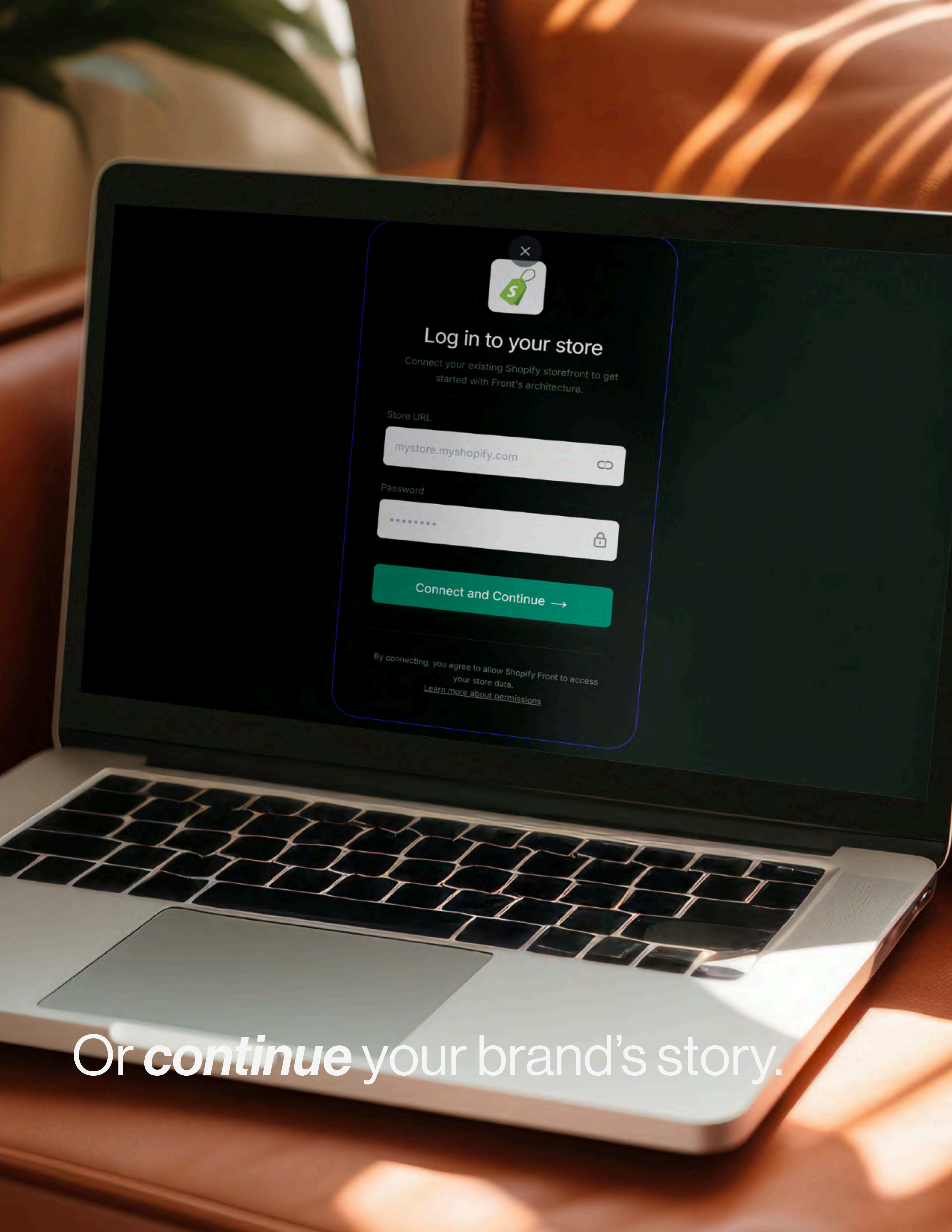
This is where observation becomes visible, and testing becomes actionable.

It allows merchants to observe behavior, identify patterns, and make decisions in real time.

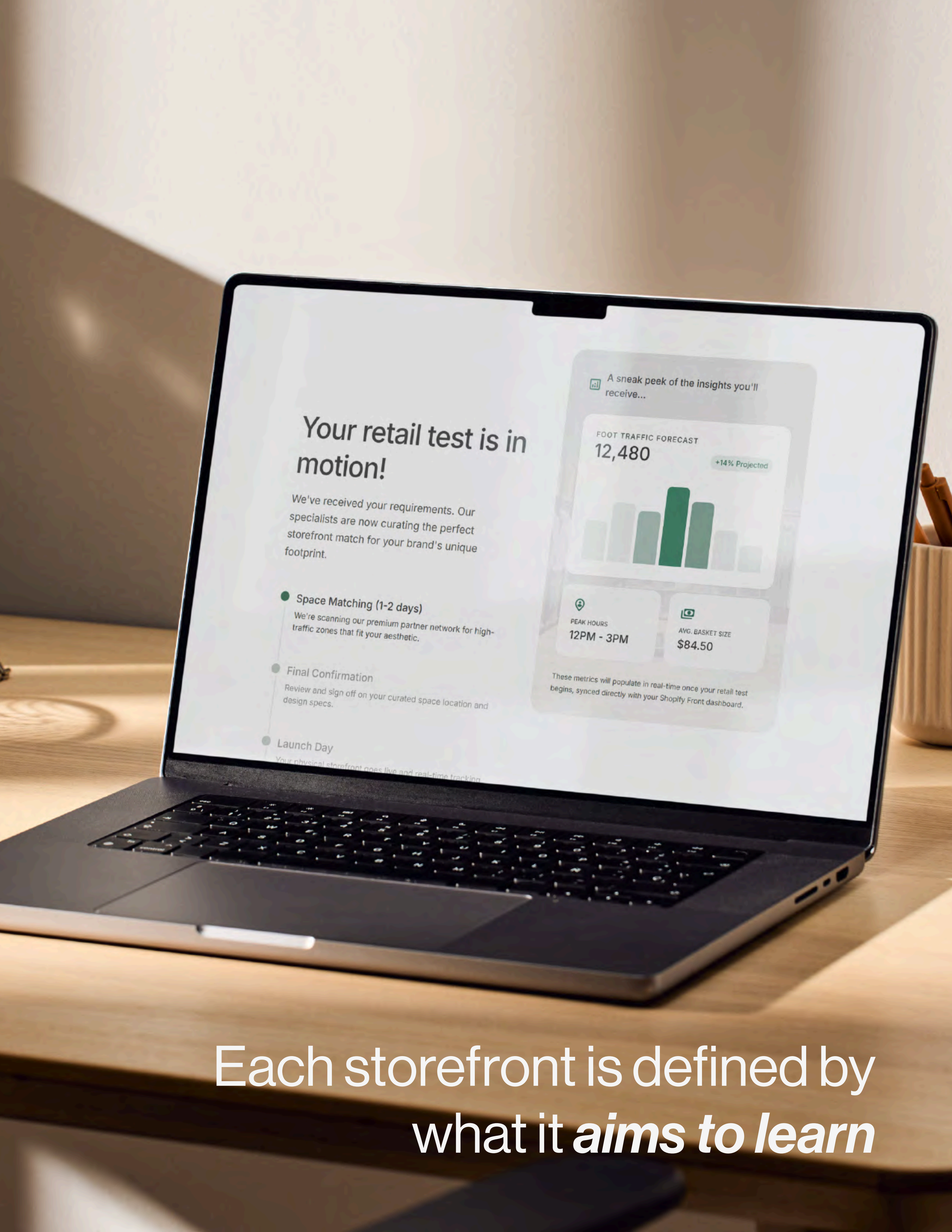


The platform translates physical interaction into usable insight.


shopify front
Goal Selection
Business Setup
Location & Format
Duration & Budget
What You Get
Review & Confirm
Tell us about your brand.
Tell us a bit about your brand so we can tailor the retail experience to your needs. No commitment, just a better start.
Low-risk setup
Your data is secured with enterprise-grade Shopify encryption.
Business Name
e.g. The Green Studio
Category
Select your industry
OR
Connect your Shopify store
Sync your inventory and settings instantly
Back
Start a new journey with
ShopifyFront.



Or *continue* your brand's story.



Each storefront is defined by what it *aims to learn*

not just what it ***aims to sell.***

Physical Layer

The storefront operates as a modular, temporary environment designed for testing.
It enables rapid setup, adjustment, and iteration without the constraints of traditional retail.
This is made possible by repositioning Shopify as a physical intermediary—bridging the gap between landlords and emerging brands.

FEASABILITY

Shopify operates as a trusted leaseholder.
Instead of merchants committing to long-term retail, Shopify secures space and enables short-term access.

The barrier is not space—it is risk.
Landlords do not trust small businesses.
They trust platforms with scale and stability.

By absorbing long-term leases and liability, Shopify allows merchants to enter physical retail without the financial burden of permanence.

SYSTEM MECHANICS

Master Lease Model
Shopify leases space long-term and provides short-term access to merchants

Flexible Occupancy
Stores operate on short cycles (1–6 months) for testing and iteration

Revenue-Based Renting
Rent can adapt based on store performance, reducing upfront risk

Pre-Certified Spaces
Standardized retail “skeletons” remove permitting delays and setup friction

The space is not permanent. It is deployable.

Making Behaviour Visible

Customer interaction is captured as behavioral signals — movement, hesitation, engagement — and translated into patterns that inform what changes next.

What was previously invisible becomes measurable.

What was assumed becomes observed.

BEHAVIOURAL INSIGHT

PRODUCT TESTING

SPATIAL TESTING

REAL-TIME OBSERVATION


PART 05
MAKING THE
SYSTEM REAL
AND DEFENSIBLE
part

05

Before something can exist
in the world,
it has to hold up to it.
Because a system is only
as strong
as the conditions it can
survive.

Brand Values

CLARITY

Information is visible, not hidden.
Decisions are based on what is observed.

TRANSPARENCY

The system reveals how things work.
No manipulation. No assumption.

ADAPTABILITY

The environment responds to real conditions.
Nothing is fixed.

PRECISION

Every change is intentional.
Driven by data, not guesswork.

where
meets

shopify
shopify front

5.1

BRAND GUIDELINES

shopify front

LOGOTYPE

shopify front

Primary horizontal lockup

BRANDMARK

Icon on dark surfaces

SUBMARK

Icon on light/mint surfaces

COLOR PALETTE

Defining depth through tonal transitions rather than lines.

#0C1510	#141E18	#95ECB8	#6DDBEB	#2A71F5
Surface Base	**Container Low**	**Primary Mint**	**Accent Blue**	**Primary Blue**
The infinite dark canvas.	Structural sectional layers.	High-energy action points.	Secondary highlights & accents.	Signal color for flow and interaction.

TYPOGRAPHY

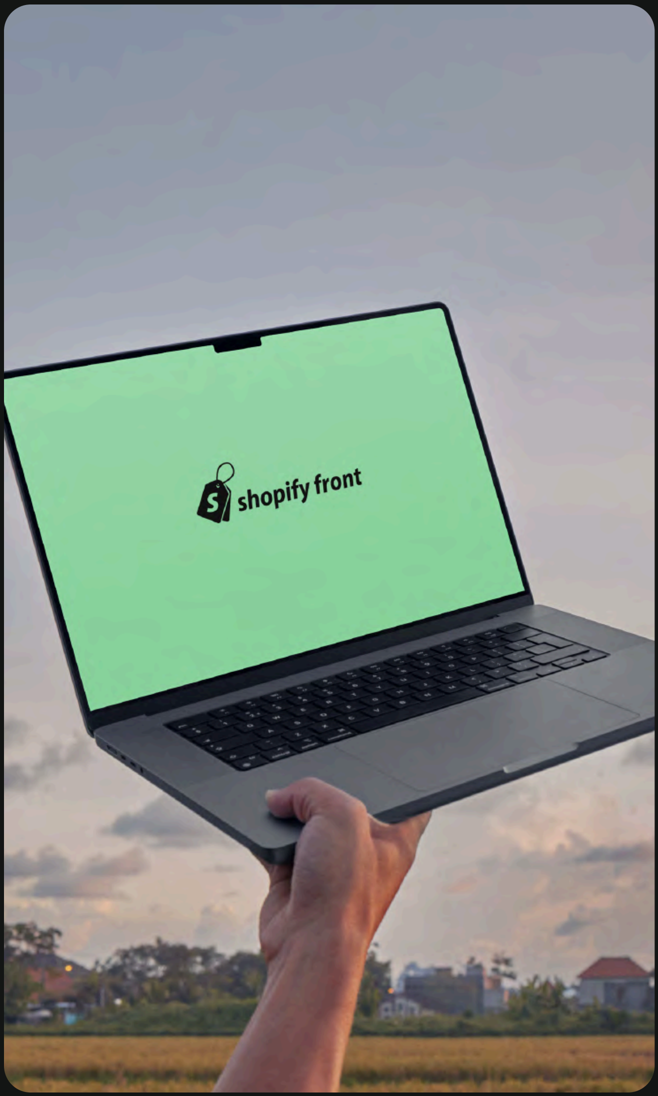
Neue Haas Grotesk Display Pro · System typeface.

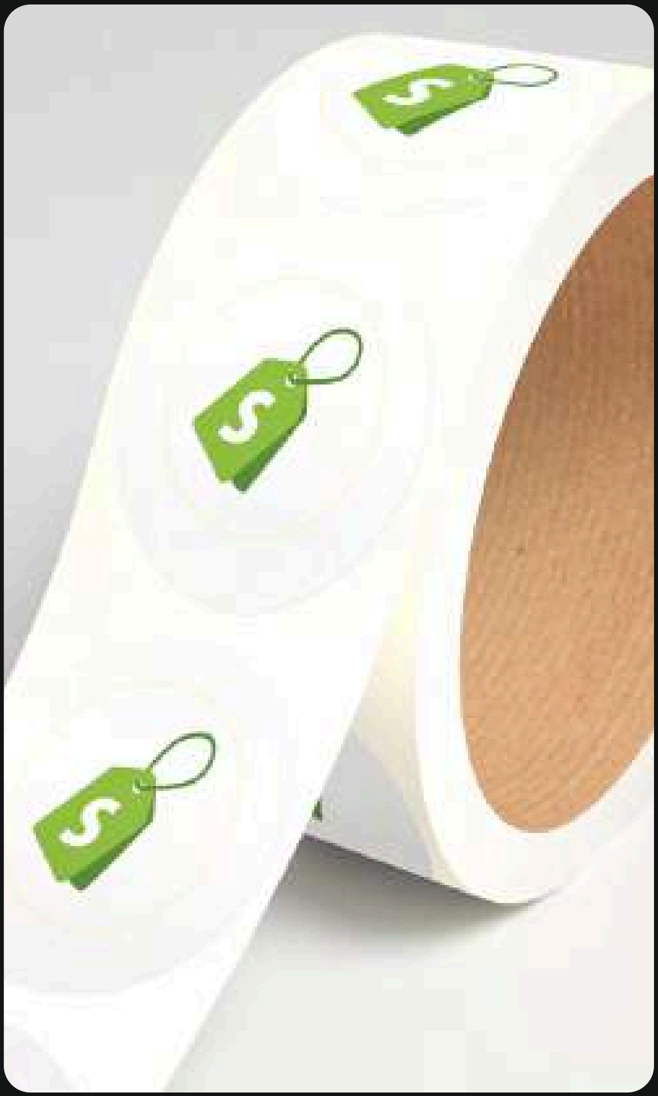
Aa Aa

Neue Haas Grotesk Display Pro

ABCDEFGHIJKLMNOPQRSTUVWXYZ
abcdefghijklmnopqrstuvwxyz
0123456789 !@#$%^&*()

WEIGHTS · 300 LIGHT · 500 MEDIUM · 700 BOLD


shopify front




shopify front
shopify front

PART 06
A DIFFERENT WAY FORWARD

part

06

This is not a final answer.
It is a shift in direction.
Because design is not
about control—
it is about what we choose
to make possible.

bye

Reflection

The greatest challenge in this project was not designing a solution, but reframing the problem itself. Physical retail does not fail because it lacks space or product, but because it lacks visibility into what happens within it. Moving from assumption to observation required a shift in perspective—from designing fixed outcomes to creating systems that can learn through real interaction.

This shift introduced a different kind of complexity. The work extended beyond interface and space into questions of feasibility, trust, and infrastructure. Designing something that could exist meant thinking through how risk is distributed, how access is enabled, and how digital systems can meaningfully connect to physical environments.

The greatest gain was understanding that design does not need to predict behavior—it can create the conditions to observe and understand it. By reframing retail as a continuous process of testing, learning, and adjustment, the role of design expands from creating experiences to building systems that evolve over time.

This project moves forward not as a final answer, but as a direction. Toward environments that are responsive, grounded in real behavior, and capable of adapting as they are used. Toward a design practice that prioritizes visibility, participation, and agency over assumption and control.

Thank you to my professors, peers, and everyone who supported and challenged this work along the way.

shopify front

MABEL EUN-HA KASUNIC
mabelkasunicdesign@gmail.com
OCAD University | Industrial Design
2026 Thesis Booklet & Report

01